a. Occupation of ancestral lands, or at least of part of them;
b. Common ancestry with the original occupants of these lands;
c. Culture in general, or in specific manifestations (such as religion, living under a tribal system, membership of an indigenous community, dress, means of livelihood, lifestyle, etc.);
d. Language (whether used as the only language, as mother-tongue, as the habitual means of communication at home or in the family, or as the main, preferred, habitual, general or normal language);
e. Residence on certain parts of the country, or in certain regions of the world;
f. Other relevant factors.

On an individual basis, an indigenous person is one who belongs to these indigenous populations through self-identification as indigenous (group consciousness) and is recognised and accepted by these populations as one of its members (acceptance by the group).

This preserves for these communities the sovereign right and power to decide who belongs to them, without external interference [emphases added].

As is evident, this working definition contains quite a few agreeable aspects since it combines elements of who are indigenous peoples and what makes them indigenous, which goes beyond ethnic considerations. That said, this definition too is better applicable to those countries with significant European settler populations, such as the Americas, New Zealand and Australia, since it is based on the premise that such indigenous groups are in a position of relative non-dominance. Application of this definition to countries like Bharat with negligible European settler population results in the same pitfalls as the ILO definitions. Effectively, it passes on the European coloniser's guilt as a legacy to the native 'dominant'/'majority national communities' of Bharat.

Further, in Bharat, this distinction based on dominant/ 'majority' national groups and marginalised/'minority' indigenous/tribal groups has only worked to the detriment of the native society since 'tribal' groups have been incongruously arrayed alongside 'religious minorities', and pitted against the rest of the 'majority' population of which they have been an organic part for millennia. While I will build more on this point in the second